

Starting things off with the synthetic GPU benchmarks. While the scores between the two laptops are very close, the RTX 4050 on the Neo 16 actually manages to pull higher scores in the majority of the benchmarks.

This trend continues with real-world gaming benchmarks as well, where save one or two games, we see higher frames on the Predator Helios Neo 16 across both the high and medium presets.

Ultimately, it all comes down to the TGP, with a higher TGP of 115 W on the RTX 4050 in the Predator Neo 16, you actually get better numbers than an RTX 4060 with a much lower TGP of 85 W. Once again, this is pretty disappointing, especially considering the price of the X14 R2. That said, the RTX 4060 is still a pretty powerful GPU, and you can comfortably game at high settings as long as you're playing at FHD resolutions. At QHD resolutions you can bump the settings down to medium and still get decent numbers.

Coming to processor performance, the processor on the Neo 16 is better than what we have on the X14 R2. We use the PCMark 10 benchmark to test productivity and it comes as no surprise that the Neo 16 pulls ahead pretty easily.

We test single-thread and multi-thread performance using the Cinebench R23 benchmark. Here, we can see that the Intel Core i7-13620H on the X14 R2 pulls slightly ahead in single-thread performance, but is no match for the Intel Core i7-13700HX in multi-thread performance; it has more cores. Again, the X14 R2 costs twice as much as the Neo 16.

Coming to storage, the Alienware X14 R2 comes with 1TB of PCIe gen 4 NVMe SSD storage. We saw read speeds north of 6000 MB/s and write speeds north of 5000 MB/s during our testing. However, the Neo 16 actually tested higher read speeds at around 7000 MB/s and around the same write speeds.

The RAM on the Alienware X14 R2 is also slightly slower, which makes sense since we're comparing LPDDR5-4800 RAM with DDR5-4800 RAM. The Alienware does come with 32GB of RAM how-



ever, which is nice, but with no room for expansion since it's integrated.

DISPLAY

If there's one thing the Alienware X14 R2 has going for it, it's the display. The display on the Alienware X14 R2 is fantastic. You have a 16:10 14-inch QHD+ (2560x1600) display with a refresh rate of 165 Hz. The laptop comes with an advertised brightness of 300 nits, and during our testing we got a peak average brightness of 335 nits. We tested 99.9 per cent sRGB coverage and 98.8 per cent DCI-P3 coverage, making this one of the best laptop displays we've tested this year. Considering the form factor, the 16:10 aspect ratio, and the specs on-board, the Alienware X14 R2 makes for an excellent portable content creation machine.

HEAT AND NOISE

Compact machines don't do too well when it comes to thermals. The Alienware X14 R2 gets pretty hot during intensive workloads but it does seem to manage internal heat fairly well. During our processor stress test, we recorded temperatures of around 80 degrees Celsius on the processor, which is not bad. The processor didn't throttle much either despite rising surface temps. Surface temps can get uncomfortably high, especially at the centre of the laptop where we saw temps north of 45 degrees

Celsius after long gaming sessions.

In terms of noise, last year's Alienware X14 got pretty loud, to the point that we compared it to a plane taking off. This time around the noise is a lot more manageable. It will still get fairly loud during intensive workloads.

VERDICT

The Alienware X14 R2 may be the thinnest 14-inch gaming laptop you can get your hands on, but it's ultimately quite disappointing. The specs are too weak for the price, which we don't think the build quality or display alone can justify. The Acer Predator Helios Neo 16 features a brighter display that's almost as good, with a higher refresh rate to boot. It also outperforms the Alienware X14 in most processor and GPU benchmarks, all which costing half as much. Sure, it doesn't feature the same build quality or portability, but I don't think that warrants 2x the price at all.

—Manish Rajesh

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Intel Core i7-13620H | 10 Cores (6P, 4E) | 16 Threads | GPU: NVIDIA GeForce RTX 4060 Laptop GPU, TGP: 85 W | RAM: 32GB-LPDDR5-4800, Integrated | Storage: 1TB M.2 NVMe SSD | Display: 14-inch, QHD+ (2560x1600), 165Hz, LCD | Dimensions: 14.50 mm x 321.08 mm x 260.41 mm | Weight: 1.91 kg

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